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The motherland's suffocating embrace: schooling and public discourse on Hong Kong identity under the National Security Law

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ABSTRACT

While 'national education' has regularly been invoked by post-1997 Hong Kong administrations, its pursuit has acquired new force and urgency since the introduction in 2020 of a National Security Law. Investigating the role of schooling in this reinvigorated project of thought reform, this article asks how far recent initiatives have merely amplified official identity discourse or marked a qualitative change. It does so primarily by analysing the official curriculum and textbooks for *Citizenship and Social Development* (CSD), introduced in 2022 to replace *Liberal Studies*, a subject widely blamed by nationalists for fomenting sedition. Following a comparative overview of the new and old curricula, there is a discussion of changes to the textbook treatment of: the historical framing of identity; the 'One Country, Two Systems' model; culture's significance for Hong Kong's place in China; and civil, legal and constitutional rights and duties. The analysis concludes with reflections on what these changes imply both for China's efforts to re-educate its unruly Hong Kong subjects, and for scholarly efforts to understand and explain such processes.

KEYWORDS

Hong Kong; China; National Security Law; national education; politics; curriculum

关键词

香港; 中国; 国家安全法; 国民教育; 政治; 课程

令人窒息的祖国怀抱：《国家安全法》下关于香港身份认同的学校教育和公共话语

摘要

虽然1997年后香港政府经常诉诸‘国民教育’，但自2020年《国家安全法》出台以来，对该教育的施行呈现新的力度和紧迫性。通过调查学校教育在这一卷土重来的思想改造工程中的角色，本文探讨这些近期举措仅是对官方身份话语的强化，亦或标志着一种质变。文章主要分析了2022年颁布的《公民与社会发展》的官方课程和教科书，该课程取代了被民族主义者广泛指责煽动暴乱的《通识教育》。在对新旧课程进行比较后，文章讨论了教科书在以下方面的变化：身份认同的历史架构、‘一国两制’模式、文化对于香港在中国地位的意义，以及公民、法律和宪法的权利与义务。文章结论将反思这些变化对中国试图重新教化不臣服的香港子民意味着什么，以及学术界该如何理解和阐释这些进程。

Introduction

Is identity inherited or acquired, conferred or constructed? Such questions are of visceral significance for the inhabitants of Hong Kong or Taiwan, where adherents of primordial 'Chineseness' confront localists for whom identity is created or reimagined by citizens themselves. Indeed, underlying identity debates is the issue of 'who decides': of who or what ultimately determines the legitimacy or illegitimacy of particular conceptions of belonging.

Classical Marxism tells us that identity should align with class interest; nationalism is a fraud perpetrated on the proletariat by exploitative elites. But China's Communists today strenuously resist this logic, insisting on an authentic 'Chineseness' irreducible to economic or sociological determinants (Xu 2021). Central to this vision is an essentialist conception of 'Han-ness' that is hard to reconcile with the multiethnic reality of today's successor state to the Qing Empire. Maintaining their imperium, China's leaders have concluded, requires denial of 'self-determination' to groups whose identities diverge from the state-mandated mainstream.

For decades, that denial coexisted with a vacillating and contradictory commitment to multiculturalism (see Yan and Vickers 2023), but under Xi Jinping the Communist Party (CCP) has embraced an emphatically culturalist, even racist, conception of nationhood. The Party has intensified efforts to assimilate 'minorities' premised on a Han-centric narrative of 'outstanding traditional Chinese culture'. Curricular uniformity and monolingualism are being imposed in regions where diversity was previously tolerated or even encouraged (Leibold and Dorje forthcoming; Bulag forthcoming). In Xinjiang and elsewhere, 'National Security' is invoked as justification, with official discourse portraying a Chinese nation threatened by a combination of subversion at home and malevolent Western 'hegemonism' abroad (Tobin 2020).

The Chineseness of the Han denizens of Taiwan and Hong Kong, even more than of the mainland's 'minorities', has always been defined in explicitly culturalist and racist terms. In August 2022, China's foreign minister, Wang Yi, described Taiwan's President Tsai Ing-wen as an 'unworthy descendent' who had betrayed her ancestors, while a prominent diplomat lamented the islanders' 'de-sinicisation' (Rennie 2022). The remedy was thoroughgoing 're-education'. In Hong Kong, a 2008 'Task Group on National Education' (TGNE) recognised multiple dimensions to citizenship, but stressed local people's distressing deficiency in *national* loyalty. The report stated that a 'sense of "we-ness"' should be cultivated by invoking '(1) racial ties, noting that we are all connected by blood as Chinese, sharing the same features of dark eyes, black hair and yellow complexion' (TGNE 2008). 'Culture and heritage' were merely a secondary source of 'we-ness'. 'Blood' and 'roots' dictate that for Han everywhere, ancestry is destiny.

The recent policy thus signifies a shift not so much in the official narrative of Hong Kong's Chineseness as in the stakes attached to bringing local consciousness into line. Ho-Fung Hung attributes to the legal scholar, Jiang Shigong (formerly attached to the central government's Hong Kong Liaison Office), the view that "'One Country, Two Systems" is just a transitional arrangement to aid in the smooth transition of ... sovereignty' (Hung 2022, 139). In other words, local autonomy was never more than a tactical ploy, implying no recognition of enduring cultural distinctiveness. Here Jiang was simply emphasising the established CCP view; more significant was his insistence that residents'

recalcitrance be remedied through ‘thought reform’. That view, amplified by the 2008 TGNE report, informed the unsuccessful 2012 bid to introduce a compulsory ‘Moral and National Education’ (MNE) school subject. The consequent cycle of youth resistance and official repression culminated, almost a decade later, in the imposition of Hong Kong’s ‘National Security Law’ (Vickers and Morris 2022).

Jiang’s minimalist definition of Hong Kong’s autonomy was associated with a maximalist vision of China’s global role, marked by a ‘positive’ take on imperialism. While deploring Britain’s ‘colonialist’ distortion of Hongkongers’ identity consciousness, Jiang admired British ‘skill and art’ (Hung 2022, 139). Empires were not intrinsically evil; in fact, restoring an imperium infused with Chinese ethnocultural essences was, for Jiang, the proper object of CCP statecraft – albeit in the context of official commitment to China’s ‘peaceful rise’. Similar views pervade much recent mainland scholarship on Hong Kong. A group of Shenzhen-based scholars portray Britain’s ‘administrative absorption of politics’ as diabolically effective in achieving an ‘illusory decolonisation’ of identity consciousness (Li, Zheng and Tan 2022, 4). British brainwashing yielded a local population possessing ‘incomplete subjectivity’ due to a lack of ‘racial self-awareness’ (4). Seeking to restore that properly racial subjectivity, mainland texts today downplay Hong Kong’s international status, stressing instead integration into a ‘Greater Bay Area’ encompassing Shenzhen, Guangzhou, Zhuhai and Macau (PEP 2019, 101) – an ‘imaginary regional formation’ that ties Hong Kong more tightly than ever to the motherland’s apron-strings (Rowen 2023).

This article examines how attempts to transform local consciousness have intensified since 2020. While ‘national education’ has regularly been invoked by post-1997 Hong Kong administrations, its pursuit has acquired new urgency since 2019. Here I investigate the role played in this project by public history and especially by schooling. I ask how far recent initiatives have merely amplified official identity discourse or marked a qualitative change. I do this primarily by analysing the official curriculum and textbooks for *Citizenship and Social Development* (CSD), introduced in 2022 to replace *Liberal Studies*, a subject widely blamed by nationalists for fomenting sedition. After broadly comparing the new and old curricula, I discuss changes to the textbook treatment of: the historical framing of identity; the ‘One Country, Two Systems’ model; culture’s significance for Hong Kong’s place in China; and civil, legal and constitutional rights and duties. I conclude by reflecting on what these changes imply both for China’s efforts to ‘re-educate’ its unruly Hong Kong subjects, and for scholarly efforts to study them.

The politics of ‘national education’ in Hong Kong

A regime that, since the 1990s, has made ‘patriotic education’ central to its legitimating strategy nationally has also seen it as important to securing loyalty within Hong Kong. Since 1997, successive Chief Executives have highlighted related initiatives in their annual policy addresses, while education officials have followed up with varying degrees of energy and enthusiasm. In the culture and heritage sector, exhibitions and performances have been framed to align both with Beijing-approved narratives and the interests of a collaborationist local elite (Vickers 2019). United Front entities have sought to foster a nationalism rooted in shared ancestry and cultural chauvinism, while camouflaging or downplaying the ideological gulf between the CCP and most local citizens.

However, until the 2020s, the capacity of the local administration to conduct thoroughgoing National Education was constrained by a number of factors. These included the professional ethos of officials in the education and heritage sectors, many of whom resisted overt politicisation (Vickers 2005). The Hong Kong Professional Teachers Union (HKPTU) gave corporate voice to educators resistant to ‘patriotic’ political socialisation. Elections lent a public platform to opponents of mainland-style ideological instruction, as, crucially, did a remarkably free and open media. And ultimately, as the MNE fiasco of 2012 showed, many citizens were ready to use their civil liberties, specifically the right to protest, to push back forcefully against unwelcome attempts at political re-education (Morris and Vickers 2015).

In other words, until 2020, different visions of identity more or less openly contended in the cultural, media and educational sectors. While certain institutions and school subjects channelled primordialist visions of national belonging congenial to Beijing, platforms existed elsewhere for the articulation of more complex, liberal or social constructionist ideas of identity. One important curricular space for such ideas was provided by the compulsory *Liberal Studies* subject. Introduced in 2009, this sought to explain the political, social and constitutional systems of both Hong Kong and the Chinese mainland, while promoting informed, participatory citizenship. But with the introduction of a parallel vehicle for patriotic education, in the form of MNE, stymied by popular opposition, *Liberal Studies* increasingly came to be seen by mainland officials and their local proxies as a trojan horse for subversion of Chinese state authority.

Anger in the pro-Beijing camp at the deficient patriotism of local youth peaked during the protests of 2019–2020, triggering demands for decisive rectification. The National Security Law (NSL) of June 2020 cleared the way by demolishing constitutional protections for the regime’s critics. Elections were restricted to officially-vetted ‘patriots’; media freedom drastically curtailed; the HKPTU and other civil society entities disbanded; and outspoken critics of the regime arrested and imprisoned. Civil servants and teachers – including foreigners – were required to swear an oath of allegiance. And under the auspices of the NSL, ‘National Security Education’ was mandated (Vickers and Morris 2022).

Related initiatives publicised on the Education Bureau’s (EDB) ‘National Education One-stop Portal’ have included training in correct handling of ‘the national flag and national symbols’ (images of workshops for ‘special schools’ showed learning-impaired students struggling to perform the required rituals) (EDB 2022a).¹ A virtual ‘exhibition’ sought to normalise the concept of ‘national security’ by stressing that ‘many countries, including the United States, the United Kingdom, Canada and Australia’ adopt ‘all possible means to safeguard it’, while implying China’s special need to ensure that ‘major interests of the State’ are ‘not threatened internally or externally’.² The exhibition invoked Xi Jinping’s ‘Holistic view of national security’, enshrined in a PRC law of 2015 that designated April 15 as ‘National Security Education Day’. The portal further publicised a ‘One Country, Two Systems and Basic Law video series’, disseminated information on ‘Love our home, treasure our country joint school activities’ and provided links to other National Education-related websites (e.g. on the Greater Bay Area).

Scepticism is often warranted concerning teachers’ actual uptake of such curricular resources. In the past, packages designed to promote civic or national education have often gathered dust in staff rooms, or been taken up by those already wedded to the cause (Morris and Adamson 2010). Curricular initiatives with little relevance to public

examination syllabi or teachers' careers typically struggle to gain traction. Government-subsidised mainland study tours, for example, were until recently non-compulsory and thus peripheral to the examination-centred business of public schooling.

Since 2020, however, the calculus for teachers, schools and students has shifted. National Education is no longer an add-on promoted through exhortation and incentives, but a requirement enforced through draconian sanctions. Crucial here is the embedding of patriotic ideology in the compulsory CSD subject (replacing *Liberal Studies*), along with new restrictions on teachers' pedagogical agency. Amidst a radical tightening of controls on media, civil society and the local heritage sector, these changes help restrict access to sources challenging officially-sanctioned narratives.

Public history and patriotic education

Hong Kong's heritage sector has long witnessed performative displays of patriotism by collaborationist elites (Vickers 2019). After 1997, pro-Beijing groups lobbied for enhanced commemoration of local links to Republican China's founding father, Dr. Sun Yat-sen: a large museum was opened in Mid-Levels; a 'Sun Yat-sen Heritage Trail' inaugurated; and a harbour-side park renamed in his honour. Local museums hosted numerous exhibitions loaned from mainland institutions, many on China's pre-modern heritage, others offering a state-centred narrative of the contemporary past. Public history has lent increasing weight to the pre-colonial era, rebalancing a previously lopsided narrative, but sometimes also serving to 'reduce the British presence to "an episode", a passing influence, rather than ... the crucial, even founding, impact that created the city we know today' (Sala 1999, 65). This intent seems to have informed a 1997 Antiquities and Monuments Office pamphlet that proclaimed '6,000 years of Hong Kong history', a millennium longer than the history typically claimed for China itself (AMO 1997).

The permanent exhibition of the Hong Kong Museum of History (HKMH) closed for a long-planned renovation in late 2020. An Expert Advisory Panel consulted over the plans included eminent historians Elizabeth Sinn and Lui Tai-lok, as well as former HKMH director, Joseph Lin.³ The panel made various suggestions consistent with a 'national education' agenda, including: that coverage of archaeology relating to local links to the ancient 'Maritime Silk Road' be enhanced; that the Opium War exhibit be rendered more 'visible'; and that the section on Japan's invasion and occupation emphasise its social consequences and 'war crimes' such as the establishment of 'comfort stations' (military-run brothels). There were calls for expanding the section on 'the Modern Metropolis and Return to China', removing a section on finance while according greater attention to issues affecting impoverished postwar migrants from mainland China, such as 'rooftop primary schools and resettlement areas' (HKMH 2020).

Beyond the HKMH, the cultural landscape has experienced a patriotic makeover since 2020. The new West Kowloon Cultural District hosts the M + suite of galleries, where the Siggs Collection of Contemporary Chinese Art includes work making daring but vague reference to the 1989 'Tiananmen events'. But if M + aims to convey nuance and sophistication, a more overtly propagandistic role is performed by the Cultural District's other key monument: the Hong Kong Branch of Beijing's National Palace Museum. A gift from the motherland to mark 25 years since the retrocession, its opening coincided with a June 2022 visit by President Xi Jinping. Red posters celebrated the inauguration

of the NPM Branch and the quarter-century ‘new era’ of ‘stability’, ‘prosperity’ and ‘opportunity’. Housing artefacts of the ‘outstanding traditional Chinese culture’ now central to CCP patriotic education, in September 2022 the museum formed the backdrop to an EDB video celebrating the October 1 National Day. Local schoolchildren, many in faux-traditional Han clothing (*Hanfu*), all in surgical masks (signalling compliance with ‘zero covid’ strictures), chanted – in *putonghua* – a setting of 少年中国说 (*On Young China*) by the early twentieth-century moderniser, Liang Qichao (梁啟超). Liang’s verses hailing youth’s importance to national revival had been echoed by Xi on July 1, when he declared ‘a nation will prosper only when its young people thrive’ (HKSARG 2022). In adapting Liang, lines such as ‘the country is strong only when youth are strong’ (少年強則國強) were retained, but his insistence that ‘the country is independent only when youth are independent’ (少年獨立則國獨立) was omitted.⁴ Obedience, not independence, is what Beijing requires of today’s patriotic youth.

Local and national history in the school curriculum

Justifying absolute obedience to state authority is a historical narrative focusing on manifold perils to China’s national security. Ever since the 1990s, Hongkongers have been exhorted to ‘study Chinese history and culture’ to overcome the deracinating legacy of colonial rule. Ironically, Hong Kong’s schools long purveyed a far more traditionalist (and unabashedly Han chauvinist) vision of Chineseness than their mainland counterparts (Luk 1991). However, as Carrico observes, the point of instructing locals to ‘study’ history or the Basic Law is to ‘construct a hierarchy between those who understand and those who do not’, mirroring that which exists ‘between those who interpret the law and those who are left to study and obey it’ (Carrico 2022, 38). The point is to recognise where the authority to define historical ‘correctness’ lies.

While museums and cultural institutions help transmit and popularise the authorised narrative, of greater importance is the school curriculum. History education in Hong Kong features a peculiar rupture between instruction in international and local history (often delivered in English), and the teaching of ‘Chinese History’ (always conducted in Chinese / Cantonese) (Kan 2007). The curriculum for Chinese History has always embodied the essentialist, culturalist, conservative vision of ‘Chineseness’ that nowadays infuses CCP discourse on ‘outstanding traditional Chinese culture’. But whereas a depoliticised culturalism appealed to many refugees in postwar Hong Kong, recent Beijing-inspired attempts to repoliticise this vision have tended to alienate a younger generation.

This has not deterred local officials from attempting to use history education to inspire patriotic enthusiasm (Vickers 2005; Kan 2007). In 2021, a fresh range of EDB ‘resources for teaching Chinese History and Culture’ recommended enhancing teaching of traditional painting, calligraphy and Cantonese opera, as well as bolstering instruction in patriotic history (EDB 2021a). Key historical topics included Qin Shihuang’s ‘unification’ of China (using material from a 2012 HKMH exhibition); ‘evidence from pictures’ on episodes from the Opium War onwards (1841–1911; 1912–1949 and 1949–1999); and the twentieth-century ‘War of Resistance’ against Japan. Also in 2021, the EDB released (in Chinese only) guidelines for using Chinese History and History to teach ‘National Security Education’ (EDB 2021b, 2021c). Aspects of the existing curriculum deemed useful for reinforcing NSE messages included: China’s unification under Emperor Qin Shihuang; the

impact of foreign invasion and ‘colonialism’ since the nineteenth century (ignoring the Qing’s own colonial empire) (EDB 2021c, 4, 11); Hong Kong’s role in national resistance to the Japanese invasion (5, 12) (neglecting the local context; see Vickers 2019); the foreign policy ‘achievements’ of the Mao era (airbrushing its domestic disasters); and developmental triumphs of the post-1978 ‘Reform and Opening’ decades (5–6; 13–14). The guidelines also suggest historically-themed ‘field trips’ to the mainland – for example, to the Humen Museum on the Opium War and to the Nanjing Massacre Memorial (EDB 2021b, 16).

However, neither History nor Chinese History are compulsory subjects at secondary level; they are options studied by a minority of students. The narratives of national and local identity that underpin curricula for compulsory subjects thus carry higher stakes. Chinese language and literature are important here, but lie beyond the scope of the present study. In the remainder of this article, I focus instead on the most explicit vehicle for political socialisation through schooling: the subject of *Citizenship and Social Development* (CSD) and its predecessor, *Liberal Studies*.

From ‘Liberal Studies’ to ‘Citizenship and Social Development’: framing curricular discourse on politics and identity

In a previous article (Vickers and Morris 2022), I show how Hong Kong’s protests of 2019–2020 witnessed intensified criticism of local education from the pro-Beijing camp. Arousing special indignation was the compulsory senior secondary subject of *Liberal Studies* (LS), seen as fostering inappropriately critical thinking amongst local youth. Even before 2019, a major reform of LS was in prospect, under cover of a drive to ‘optimise’ the senior secondary curriculum. Focusing on the ‘four senior secondary core subjects’ – Maths, Chinese Language, English and LS – a committee was tasked with finding ways of freeing up space for ‘elective subjects’ and ‘other learning experiences’.

First in line for the chop was *Liberal Studies*. Responding to the report in early 2021, the EDB proposed a cut in teaching hours for the subject from 250 to around 130 (EDB 2021d), while rebranding it as CSD. Meanwhile, topping the list of ‘other learning experiences’ to be promoted was ‘Moral and Civic Education’. In practice, this has meant a significant increase in ‘National Education’ and NSE activities, encroaching on time for less politicised ‘learning experiences’.

A comparison of the official curricular frameworks for LS and CSD (Table 1) indicates the political implications of this shift. The framework for *Liberal Studies* consisted of three broad ‘areas of study’: ‘self and personal development’; ‘society and culture’; and ‘science, technology and the environment’. By contrast, the CSD curriculum focuses exclusively on the ‘society and culture area’, revising its themes to reflect the government’s ideological priorities: ‘Hong Kong Today’ becomes ‘Hong Kong under One Country, Two Systems’; ‘Modern China’ is now ‘Our Country since Reform and Opening Up’, and ‘Globalization’ has morphed into ‘Interdependence and Interconnectedness of the Contemporary World’ (echoing Xi Jinping’s slogan: ‘Community of Shared Destiny for Mankind’). ‘Independent enquiry study’, a major component of LS, has been deleted, with CSD instead mandating a compulsory ‘Mainland Study Tour’.

Crucially, while the LS framework merely suggested ‘key questions for enquiry’ (Table 2; CDC and HKEAA 2014, 25–39), the CSD guidelines stipulate ‘main points for study’ (學習重

Table 1. Curriculum framework for Liberal Studies, from *Liberal Studies Curriculum and Assessment Guide, Secondary 4-6, 2007, with updates 2014* (CDC and HKEAA 2014, 11) and for *Citizenship and Social Development* (EDB 2021e).

Liberal Studies: Areas of Study	Citizenship and Social Development: Themes and sub-themes:
Self & Personal Development	
Module 1: Personal Development & Interpersonal Relationships	(1) 'Hong Kong under One Country, Two Systems' (「一國兩制」下的香港) 'The meaning and implementation of "One Country, Two Systems"' (「一國兩制」的內涵和實踐) 'Situation of the country and sense of national identity' (國家情況與國民身分認同) 'Characteristics of cultural diversity of Hong Kong Society' (香港社會的多元文化特徵)
Society & Culture	
- Module 2: Hong Kong Today - Module 3: Modern China - Module 4: Globalization	
Science, Technology & the Environment	
- Module 5: Public Health - Module 6: Energy Technology & the Environment	(2) 'Our Country since Reform and Opening Up' (改革開放以來的國家) 'Change in people's life and overall national strength' (人民生活的轉變與綜合國力) The development of our country and the integration of Hong Kong into overall national development (國家的發展與香港融入國家發展大局) Participation in international affairs (參與國際事務)
Independent Enquiry Study (IES) Students are required to conduct an IES making use of the knowledge and perspectives gained from the three Areas of Study and extending them to new issues or contexts. To help students develop their IES titles, the following themes are suggested:	
- Media - Education - Religion - Sports - Art - Information and Communication Technology (ICT)	(3) Interdependence and Interconnectedness of the Contemporary World (互聯相依的當代世界)* 經濟全球化 (economic globalisation) 科技發展與資訊素養 (technological development and information quality) 可持續發展 (sustainable development) 公共衛生與人類健康 (public hygiene and human health)

In addition to study of the above themes, a 'Mainland Study Tour' is a compulsory component of the new CSD curriculum.

*Textbooks not yet published as of 2022; my translation of the sub-themes

點) (EDB 2021e, 7–8 and 11–17). Accompanying this shift were new arrangements for curriculum development and textbook approval. *Liberal Studies* was meant to foster 'enquiry' and skills of critical thinking and analysis. Exceptionally, the government thus refrained from 'approving' textbooks for use in schools; teachers were encouraged to create their

Table 2. 'Key Questions for Enquiry' on 'Hong Kong Today' and 'Modern China' themes in the *Liberal Studies* curriculum framework (HKSARG 2022; CDC and HKEAA 2014, 14).

Hong Kong Today:
1. 'Quality of Life': Which directions might be chosen in maintaining and improving Hong Kong residents' quality of life?
2. 'Rule of Law and Socio-Political Participation': How do Hong Kong residents participate in political and social affairs and come to grips with rights and responsibilities with respect to the rule of law?
3. 'Identity': How are the identities of Hong Kong residents developed?
Modern China:
1. China's reform and opening up: What impact has reform and opening-up had on the overall development of the country and on people's life?
2. Chinese culture and modern life:
With respect to the evolution of concepts of the family, what kind of relationship between traditional culture and modern life has been manifested?
To what extent are traditional customs compatible with modern Chinese society?

own instructional materials. In practice, most teachers relied heavily on conventional, commercially published textbooks, which were often distinctly circumspect in dealing with Chinese politics (Vickers 2011). But in their treatment of local issues, texts were often far more critical and challenging (see below).

Lack of clear content guidelines or vetting of textbooks for LS had been vehemently critiqued by pro-Beijing media; while endorsing, in general terms, critical thinking ‘skills’, such commentary emphasised that exercising such skills required a ‘correct’ empirical foundation (Vickers and Morris 2022). Echoing such views, the CSD curriculum guide features genuflections towards the importance of ‘reflection’, skills of ‘analysis’ and ‘multi-perspectival thinking’, but stresses that this should be preceded by instruction in ‘facts’ (EDB 2021d). The document proceeds to adumbrate unabashedly ideological ‘key learning points’ (Table 1), allowing little scope for critical enquiry.

CSD’s narrative framing of Hong Kong’s development leaves no room for ‘interpretation’ of local constitutional or legal arrangements. The first three ‘learning foci’ relating to Hong Kong (Table 1, CSD Theme 1) embody a story of violated sovereignty underlining the imperative of ‘national security’:

- (1) Summary of the origins of the Hong Kong question (問題) (the three ‘unequal treaties’ and their background) and the process of the return to the motherland (回歸過程);
- (2) Constitutional relationship between the country and the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region (HKSAR) (China has indisputable sovereignty and jurisdiction over Hong Kong); and the legal basis of ‘One Country, Two Systems’ and the Basic Law;
- (3) Significance of safeguarding national security (‘holistic concept of national security’); the ‘Hong Kong National Security Law’ and promotion of Hong Kong’s long-term development; and striking a balance between the rule of law and human rights.

Only then does the curriculum turn to ‘the Political structure of the HKSAR’, ‘Significance of the rule of law’ and ‘Fundamental rights and duties of Hong Kong residents as stipulated in the Basic Law’ (EDB 2021d, 12).

The CSD curriculum also interweaves ‘national’ and ‘local’ content in a manner calculated to blur any sense of ‘Hong Kong’ and ‘China’ as politically or culturally distinct. Religious use of the term ‘Our Country’ (國家 or 我國) avoids any implication that China is somewhere ‘other’ than Hong Kong. The *Hong Kong Today* section of *Liberal Studies* concerned itself entirely with Hong Kong, but more than one-third of content under the CSD theme ‘Hong Kong under One Country, Two Systems’ consists of celebration of China’s development and the CCP’s modernising achievements, seen as essential to anchoring students’ ‘sense of national identity’. Mirroring this mainland intrusion into coverage of Hong Kong, the CSD ‘Our Country’ theme involves extensive discussion of ‘the integration of Hong Kong into overall national development’. This is sandwiched between topics on ‘Change in people’s life and overall national strength’ and ‘[China’s] participation in international affairs’. The former celebrates the achievements of China’s post-1978 ‘Reform and Opening’: ‘enhancement’ of the ‘quality of life’ (from consumption to education and healthcare) and consequent ‘enhancement of overall national strength’ (economic, cultural, educational, scientific, and military). ‘Learning points’ listed under ‘participation in international affairs’ single out China’s promotion of ‘multifaceted diplomacy’ (全方位

外交理念) (contrasted with the USA's unipolar 'hegemony'), its 'actions and initiatives' to assist other countries and support internationalism (e.g. the 'Belt and Road Initiative'), and the 'active role' to be played by Hong Kong in advancing China's international agenda (EDB 2021e, 16).

The integration of 'national' and 'local' content is mandated also for the topic of 'interdependence and interconnectedness of the contemporary world'. I do not discuss this in any detail here, since, as of the time of writing (late 2022), textbooks for this third 'theme' have yet to be published. But the curriculum guide stipulates that discussion of contemporary world affairs should explain the roles of 'the country and Hong Kong' in relation to each of four sub-themes (Table 1; EDB 2021e, 21). On the final theme, 'Public Hygiene and Human Health', the guide notes the contribution of 'the country and Hong Kong' to controlling the global spread of infectious diseases. SARS is specifically mentioned (EDB 2021e, 21), but China's vaunted 'success' in controlling Covid-19 will likely feature in textbook coverage (notwithstanding the chaotic abandonment of 'Zero Covid' in December 2022).

The introduction of CSD has been accompanied not only by a new textbook vetting process, but also by a significant reshuffle of authors and consultants. Benny Tai, the jailed Hong Kong University law professor who inspired the 2014 'Occupy Central' movement, has had his role as textbook consultant terminated along with his liberty (Vickers and Morris 2022). Meanwhile, less activist liberal academics have been supplanted by impeccably patriotic figures. The eminent social historian Lui Tai-Lok, consultant on the *New Horizon* series of *Liberal Studies* texts issued by the Hong Kong Educational Publishing Company (HKEPC), has been replaced as 'reviewer' of the equivalent CSD series by Tang Fei (鄧飛). Tang, Vice-President of the Hong Kong Federation of Education Workers (the pro-Beijing teachers union), has since 2021 been a member of Hong Kong's Legislative Council (selected by the Beijing-appointed 'Election Committee'). His extravagantly 'patriotic' public posturing has enabled officials to appear relatively moderate; in July 2022, he suggested filling vacant school places with 'fully-sponsored' mainland students, prompting a gentle rebuttal by the Education Secretary (RTHK 2022). Joining Tang as a 'reviewer' of the 2022 *New Horizon* series was Hoey Simon Lee, 'chief strategy officer for the Greater Bay Area' at 'China Resources' (CRC or 华润), a vast Shenzhen-based state-owned conglomerate. Lee, also an appointed Legco member, holds a doctorate in 'Juridical Science' from Beijing's Tsinghua University, where he specialised in the study of Hong Kong's Basic Law and constitutional system.⁵

Textbook treatment of identity, culture and civil liberties

To understand what these changes in curricular guidelines, textbook vetting and authorship mean for teaching and learning, it is instructive to compare CSD texts with their *Liberal Studies* equivalents. As of autumn 2022, textbooks covering the first two CSD themes (*Hong Kong under One Country Two Systems* and *Our Country since Reform and Opening Up*) have been published. For the purposes of this article, I compare the *New Horizon* CSD series published by HKEPC, widely used in more 'academic' local high schools, with the most recent (2020) editions of the *New Horizon Liberal Studies* texts (Hung, Chow, and Hui Tai 2020; Poon 2020). Unlike earlier *Liberal Studies* texts, the latter had been 'voluntarily' subjected to EMB screening under a scheme introduced in late 2019 (Vickers and Morris 2022, 195). The contrast between these two textbook

editions is thus revealing of the new approach to curricular ‘guidance’ and textbook censorship ushered in by the National Security Law of 2020.

The *New Horizon* CSD texts are superficially similar to their *Liberal Studies* predecessors in design, layout and unit structure, as well as authorship (Tang and Lee are billed as ‘reviewers’ rather than authors). But in content they are radically different, adhering closely to the revised and newly prescriptive section and topic headings set out in the official guidelines. Rather than attempting a comprehensive analysis of the textbooks, I focus here on their treatment of the relationships between Hong Kong and mainland China, and the local and central authorities. I consider how these relationships are contextualised with reference to: narratives of local or national history; interpretation of the ‘One Country, Two Systems’ concept; portrayal of culture, particularly in relation to representation of Hong Kong’s place in China; and the treatment of civil rights, political participation, and limitations thereto stemming from ‘national security’ considerations.

Identity and historical context

The 2020 edition of the ‘Hong Kong Today’ Liberal Studies (LS) text features no systematic historical framing of Hong Kong’s development, and little discussion of the region’s political history (Hung, Chow, and Hui Tai 2020). There is little reference to Britain’s role in shaping local institutions. The text instead focuses almost exclusively on contemporary economic, social and livelihood issues; and on political, civic or juridical rights. It begins with a section on ‘Quality of Life’, inviting students to consider different meanings of this concept, and tracking shifting ‘subjective perceptions of living conditions’ in the context of Hong Kong’s development from the 1950s to 2010s (8–9). In bold, the text reminds students that ‘a rich society is not necessarily suitable to live in or a society with high quality of life’ (9). The chapter ends by asking ‘Are Hong Kong students happy’, presenting data on leisure time and examination-related stress indicating many are not (15–16). Survey data is also cited showing Hong Kong’s low overall ranking for ‘happiness’ and very low average ‘disposable income after rent’ compared to Tokyo, Seoul and Singapore (26–27).

The 2020 LS text is peppered with allusions to aspects of postwar local history designed to contextualise contemporary economic, socio-cultural or political issues. A section on ‘The ups and downs of Hong Kong’s economy’ (24–25) transgresses a long-standing taboo by referring to an influx of ‘refugees’ from mainland China during the Chinese Civil War,⁶ who brought ‘a huge amount of capital, skill and labour’. Elsewhere, for example in the ‘Theme 3’ section on ‘Identity and Sense of Identity’, this phenomenon is euphemistically described as ‘population mobility’. A discussion of ‘Reasons for the multiple identities of Hong Kong residents’ (171) notes that ‘Hong Kong is a society of immigrants’, and that ‘from the 1940s to 1960s’, many ‘mainland residents moved to Hong Kong because of social unrest’. That first generation ‘usually treated Hong Kong as a shelter or temporary residence’ and identified strongly ‘with China’, whereas later generations ‘developed a sense of identity as a “Hongkonger”’. The text notes that, following the 1997 handover, some local residents began to identify more closely with China. However, increased migration from the mainland meant both an influx of new residents identifying with China, and a backlash amongst locals, explained thus: ‘with the increasing number of Individual Visit Scheme visitors in recent years, Hong Kong residents’ lives have been affected. This weakens their sense of belonging as Chinese’ (171).

The 2022 CSD text accords starkly different treatment to history and identity. Whereas the LS text celebrates diverse and plural identities, relating these to aspects of the local past, the CSD text portrays identity as monolithically Chinese and rooted in a unilinear narrative of the local past. At no point are students invited to mull diverse or evolving perceptions of ‘quality of life’ or recent dissatisfaction amongst local residents (let alone the role of mainland immigration in causing this). Instead, the opening unit on ‘The meaning and implementation of one country, two systems’ begins with a 22-page ‘Brief introduction to the origin of the question of Hong Kong (the three unequal treaties and their background) and the process of Hong Kong’s return to China’ (Hung et al. 2022, 4–26). As in the 2020 LS text, each chapter opens with a summary of the ‘knowledge’, ‘skills’ and ‘attitudes’ it aims to foster, but these take on a newly didactic and politicised character: students are to be taught to ‘express arguments clearly ... based on facts and evidence’, and instilled with ‘the sense of identity and belonging to our country and Chinese nation’ (sic.) (4). This entails showing that Hong Kong ‘has been part of the territory of China since ancient times’ (5); that the ‘Hong Kong Question’ arises from the region’s illegitimate sundering from the motherland as a consequence of ‘unequal treaties’ (7–12); and that their illegitimacy means that ‘Hong Kong does not fall under the category of colonial territories’ (12), even though Britain practised ‘typical colonial rule’ there before 1997 (13).

Explaining ‘one country, two systems’

The 2020 LS text features very little explicit reference to the ‘one country, two systems’ concept or slogan itself, instead stressing how Hong Kong’s Basic Law underpins ‘the rule of law’ and local arrangements for ‘socio-political participation’ (Hung, Chow, and Hui Tai 2020, Chapter 4). ‘Rule of law’ as practised in ‘the United States, the United Kingdom and Hong Kong’ is contrasted with the ‘rule of man’ as practised in ‘some totalitarian countries’ such as ‘North Korea’ (99). The text avoids discussing whether ‘rule of law’ pertains in mainland China, but portrays the Basic Law as delineating the ‘ambits of governance of the HKSAR and the Central Government’, thus ‘maintaining social stability in Hong Kong’ (102). The Basic Law is represented as having ‘supreme status’ within Hong Kong, since it ‘formulates in the form of law important concepts such as “One Country, Two Systems”’ (103). The vision adumbrated in the 2020 LS text thus treats the ‘one country, two systems’ concept as the basis for a constitutional settlement definitively separating the mainland and local legal systems, guaranteeing local autonomy and a range of civil rights that are detailed at length (see below).

In the 2022 CSD text, by contrast, the ‘One Country, Two Systems’ principle is invoked to legitimate the absolute supremacy of China’s central government. An entire chapter (its core message once again bracketed in the title) deals with the ‘Constitutional relationship between the country and the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region (HKSAR) (China has indisputable sovereignty and jurisdiction over Hong Kong), legal basis of “one country, two systems” and the Basic Law’ (Hung 2022, 27). It is emphasised that China is a ‘unitary state’, not a federation, and that therefore all ‘powers of local state organs’ are ‘granted by the Central Authorities’ (30). This axiom is illustrated by a map of China comparing ‘autonomous regions’ such as Xinjiang and Tibet with Hong Kong and Macau, a parallel calculated to erase any doubt concerning the limits to local autonomy. Invoking the legal term ‘residual power’ (‘power that is not listed in the constitution or the constitutional law’), the text further explains that, for Hong Kong, this resides exclusively

with the central authorities (31). The text lists certain powers exercised by the Hong Kong authorities, stressing that these are delegated and thus ultimately subject to central government oversight. 'The high degree of autonomy of the HKSAR', it is explained, 'is subject to the level of the central leadership's authorisation' (31). In language echoing current 'Morality and Rule by Law' textbooks on the Chinese mainland (Vickers 2022, 10), the text declares that "one country" is the prerequisite for and foundation of "two systems", while "two systems" are subordinate to and derive from "one country" (43).

The 'attitudes and values' CSD seeks to inculcate through study of the 'one country, two systems' concept are 'the consciousness of safeguarding "one country, two systems", and 'patriotism' (27). In pursuit of these aims, the text is peppered with quotations from Xi Jinping, including his representation of 'one country' as being 'like the roots of a tree' which must 'run deep and strong' for the tree to grow 'tall and luxuriant' (43). Students are reminded that the ultimate 'intention' of Article 31 of the Chinese constitution, enshrining 'One Country, Two Systems', is to 'end secession and maintain the prosperity of Taiwan and the whole motherland'. Taiwan, it is affirmed, 'will enjoy a high degree of autonomy' after 'peaceful reunification' (43).

'Culture' and the Hong Kong-China relationship

Different narratives of the origins and extent of Hong Kong's autonomy imply very different premises concerning culture's relationship with identity. A chapter in the 2020 LS text on 'Hong Kong residents' sense of identity' asks whether 'young people lack a sense of national identity', presenting 2007–2019 data showing falling identification as 'Chinese' and rising identification as 'Hongkongese'. The text discusses factors pulling Hongkongers in different directions – ideas of 'race and blood relations' favouring identification with China, with 'historical factors' stemming from legacies of 'British colonial rule' complicating matters (Hung, Chow, and Hui Tai 2020, 195). 'Political' and 'economic' factors are also considered. There is reference to a local tradition of anti-Japanese nationalism rooted in memories of war and tensions over the Diaoyu/Senkaku Islands (196). The Belt and Road and 'Greater Bay Area' initiatives are represented as bringing new opportunities for investment and economic growth, but increased migration and enhanced transport links with the mainland are portrayed as double-edged in influencing local sentiment towards China. The impact of these various factors on different groups and generations is illustrated by a graphic showing fictional individuals explaining their conceptions of identity. A young woman holding a placard demanding 'Better livelihood' declares, 'Despite Hong Kong's reunification with the motherland, Hong Kong practises 'One Country, Two Systems' and enjoys a high degree of autonomy as well as the rights of protest and demonstrations. I think I am more a Hongkonger than Chinese' (198).

The same chapter stresses the 'multiple' nature of identity, emphasising the social benefits of acknowledging this: 'Possessing multiple identities means that an individual possesses opportunities to interact and get along with people of different identities. This can increase his/her degree of tolerance to different people and events and thus improve his/her adaptability' (202). The text warns that 'using the mainstream culture to unify or assimilate other cultures ... creates tension among groups and even disrupts social stability' (202). The authors argue that societies tolerant or supportive of the expression of multiple identities tend to be more 'harmonious' and freer (203). Substantiating this emphasis on 'diversity' are references to the fact that 'Hong Kong residents'

include non-Chinese, as well as ethnic Chinese holding foreign passports. There are also references in the LS text to the longstanding presence in Hong Kong of ethnic groups such as South Asians – although no acknowledgement of the important role of the large population of Filipino maids.

In the CSD text, by contrast, culture is emphatically neither fluid nor constructed, but irrevocably ‘roots’ Hong Kong in China (to borrow Xi’s metaphor). The text repeatedly emphasises ‘Chinese culture as the mainstay’ of local identity. Far from acknowledging cultural plurality and complexity, a binary distinction is drawn between ‘Chinese’ and ‘foreign’ cultures. The relationship of these elements within Hong Kong is portrayed hierarchically, with Chinese culture to be ‘identified with and respected’ (認同與尊重), and cultural diversity ‘understood and embraced’ (Hung et al. 2022, 242). The foundational importance of ‘Chinese culture’ is underlined through extended discussion of its historical presence in the region, from ‘the Yangshao culture’ of ‘7,000–6,000 years ago’ (244) to Hong Kong’s role in ‘the anti-Japanese national salvation movement’ of the 1930s–40s (254). The ‘meaning’ (內涵) of ‘traditional Chinese culture’, which ‘has never been interrupted and has continued to this day’, is essentialised: it is ‘humanistic and people-oriented’; advocates ‘unity of man and nature, ... patriotism, morality, self-improvement and ... difference within harmony’; and promotes ‘traditional values such as filial piety, benevolence, righteousness, diligence, thrift and eagerness to learn’ (245).

The role of ‘British rule’ in shaping local institutions is acknowledged, but its cultural impact is portrayed as superficial and of merely instrumental significance. The text cites the ‘governance system’ (vesting supreme authority in a Governor), ‘business culture’, ‘education’ (specifically use of English) and a ‘modern newspaper industry’, omitting any mention of the legal or judicial systems. Hong Kong’s ‘unique’ blend of ‘cultural diversity with Chinese culture as the mainstay’ is characterised as comprising ‘inclusiveness’, ‘openness’, ‘diversity’ and ‘commerciality’ (259) – reflecting the longstanding establishment emphasis on Hong Kong as an apolitical ‘place to do business’. Rather than intrinsically desirable, ‘cultural diversity in Hong Kong’ is portrayed as instrumentally useful for promoting ‘economic development’ (263).

This narrowly instrumentalist evaluation of ‘cultural diversity’ is echoed in the CSD volume on *Our Country*, where discussion of ‘the integration of Hong Kong into the overall national development’ focuses on economic ‘development opportunities’ (Poon 2022, 106–197). At the national level, ‘cultural development’ is portrayed as contributing to ‘overall national strength’ (綜合國力), both ‘spiritual’ and ‘material’, with Xi Jinping quoted on the importance of ‘spiritual strength’ (74). Invoking the CCP’s 18th Congress (2012), the text stresses ‘restoring cultural confidence’ as essential to the ‘great rejuvenation of the Chinese nation’ (73). ‘Cultural-ethical enhancement’ in Hong Kong is illustrated by local primary students, dressed in *Hanfu*, studying ‘Chinese culture and virtues’ through ‘Chinese national learning’ (國學) (74). But here, too, culture’s instrumental importance as ‘soft power’ – enhancing China’s global influence and ‘peaceful rejuvenation’ – is emphasised (75). Hong Kong is an object of instruction in Chinese ‘spirit’, a conduit for projection of national ‘soft power’, and a venue for profitable cultural enterprise. A two-page text discussing ‘How can Hong Kong culture be promoted under the 14th Five-year Plan?’ (144–145) entertains no conception of local cultural distinctiveness. Instead, the region is portrayed as ‘an East-meets-West centre for international cultural exchange’ (145; 135–136). The text stresses opportunities for cultural investment and

scope for boosting ‘confidence among ... 40,000 cultural start-ups’ (144). All this is framed by a vision of Hong Kong’s economic future within the ‘Greater Bay Area’, guided by the CCP’s national ‘Five Year Plans’.

Values, civil rights and ‘national security’

Central to much localist consciousness has been a visceral attachment to the rights and civil liberties distinguishing Hong Kong from the Chinese mainland. This distinctiveness was celebrated in LS textbooks as recently as 2020. A unit on ‘The relationship between the spirit of the rule of law and rights and responsibilities’ highlights sometimes tense and controversial trade-offs. A two-page spread invites students to consider whether ‘Occupy Central’ harmed ‘the interests of Hong Kong society’, summarising the views of various ‘stakeholders’ (Hung, Chow, and Hui Tai 2020, 116–117). In offering a variety of opinions, the text maintains a scrupulous neutrality, but legitimising debate over politically contentious topics implies endorsement of the right to protest. A subsequent chapter on ‘The socio-political participation of Hong Kong residents’ details ‘types’ of participation, citing involvement in ‘July 1 marches’ (marking Hong Kong’s retrocession to China) and ‘joining June 4 vigils’ (commemorating the 1989 Tiananmen Massacre) as forms of ‘collective action’ aimed at ‘arousing people’s concern’ (127). The following chapter on ‘The government’s responses to the demands of different groups and the impact of such responses’ (152–165) introduces actors that, as of early 2020, still comprised an exceptionally vibrant and diverse local civil society.

By contrast, almost all discussion of the right to protest is excised from CSD textbooks. No longer invited to consider instances of social conflict and to debate the issues at stake, students are instead given a didactic exposition of the government’s views on constitutional, political and legal matters. An entire chapter explains the ‘significance of safeguarding national security’, focusing on ‘striking the balance between rule of law and human rights’ (Hung 2022, 52–72). Maintaining the format of the earlier LS text, a ‘stakeholder forum’ offers views on the question: ‘How can the National Security Law promote Hong Kong’s long-term development?’ (68). But now, all viewpoints are those of establishment figures, promoting the same official line. It is made clear that ‘balance’ between ‘rights’ and ‘rule of law’ requires prioritising ‘holistic national security’, encompassing almost every conceivable field of human activity, from ‘economics’, ‘culture’, ‘science and technology’, ‘ecology’ and ‘overseas interests’ to ‘outer space’ (69).

Following this exposition of ‘national security’ is a chapter on the ‘political structure of the Hong Kong SAR’, again substituting didactic exposition for issues-based debate. After surveying local political and judicial institutions, the chapter explains how ‘improving the electoral system’ relates to ‘patriots administering Hong Kong’ (91). The text justifies the introduction under the National Security Law of ‘oath-taking’ for public servants, including elected officials – a measure that since 2020 has excluded almost all pro-democracy politicians from elected office. Only then, in the two concluding chapters of the section on ‘One Country, Two Systems’ (96–132), does the focus turn to ‘rule of law’ and the ‘fundamental rights and duties of Hong Kong residents’. Here we find a half-page section on ‘The freedom and right to express opinions’, including ‘freedom of association, of assembly, of procession and of demonstration’. But in bold type, readers are reminded that **‘these rights are not absolute. While the law guarantees the freedom and right to express opinions, it also restricts the exercise of these rights’** (122).

Beyond the textbooks: paternalism and individuating explanations of youth alienation

These drastic changes to the pedagogy and ideological content of textbooks for the subject formerly known as *Liberal Studies* thus seek to delegitimize challenges to the local or national *status quo* – even as (or precisely because) such challenges have become acute within Hong Kong. The 2019–20 protests were fuelled by a range of grievances – not least the perception that local youth were losing out to incoming mainlanders in the competition for jobs, homes and opportunities, in a context of extreme and rising social inequality. *Liberal Studies* invited debate on such issues, with teaching materials portraying Hong Kong as a society where citizens could freely challenge perceived injustices. By contrast, CSD textbooks convey a vision of local society where all is for the best, implicitly framing attacks on the established order as threats to the security and prosperity offered by ever-greater integration with ‘the nation’.

The government is nonetheless acutely conscious of youthful discontent, even while seeking to locate its causes elsewhere than in political or socio-economic injustice. The symbolic date of July 1, 2022 marked the formal establishment of a new *Home and Youth Affairs Bureau*. On this day, the 25th anniversary of Hong Kong’s retrocession, the visiting Xi Jinping made ‘youth’ a central theme of a speech (see above) cited by the new Bureau when, in December, it launched its *Development Blueprint for Youth* (HKSARG 2022). Alice Mak, Secretary for Home and Youth Affairs, declared that ‘Our vision is to nurture a new generation of young people with an affection for our country and Hong Kong, and equipped with global perspective, an aspiring mind-set and positive thinking’ (HKSARG 2022). The four key themes of the *Blueprint* were:

- (1) Exploration – encouraging exploration, preparing for the future.
- (2) Hope – instilling hope, fulfilling dreams.
- (3) Empowerment – resilience and whole-person development.
- (4) Contribution – youth engagement and contribution to society (HKSARG 2022).

The *Youth Blueprint* represents a confluence of mainland-inflected patriotic education with a wider, global trend for depoliticised ‘social and emotional learning’ (Mochizuki, Vickers, and Bryan 2022). While signalling solicitude for youth and an embrace of ‘positive thinking’, this approach portrays the causes of youth discontent as psychological rather than political or social. The central message is that the route to a better life lies not in action to reform society, but in a determination to transform the self. This twenty-first-century recapitulation of the nineteenth-century gospel of ‘self-help’ represents an ironic if unconscious tribute to Hong Kong’s Victorian roots, while also chiming with the Communist Party’s tirades against European-style ‘welfarism’ (Vickers 2022). The same drive to ‘psychologise’ youth problems is evident in the Education Bureau’s *My Pledge to Act* project for 2019–2022, which exhorts students to be ‘happy’ and ‘grateful for what we have’ (EDB 2022b) – echoing approaches favoured by mainland officials (Wan and Vickers forthcoming) and by defenders of vested interests everywhere (Kim 2022).

Early commentary on the new *Youth Blueprint* came from Lui Tai-lok, Anthony Cheung Bing-leung and Brian Wong, participating in an EdUHK *Policy Dialogue*: ‘Giving Hope to

Young People: What matters and how?⁷ Tactfully criticising the *Blueprint*, Lui and Cheung were at pains to portray youthful rebellion in Hong Kong as a local manifestation of a global phenomenon, pointing to examples of youth alienation around the world. Lui argued that Hong Kong's situation was one instance of failure by 'governments' to engage in meaningful dialogue with young people. All three panellists nonetheless insisted that the *Blueprint* would fail in its declared aims unless it addressed young people's political engagement and their perceived lack of agency. Notwithstanding their invocations of 'global' context, this critique sounded daringly frank. But its futility was also inescapable, since denial of political dialogue and agency are intrinsic to an official agenda whose core message to Hong Kong's alienated youth is, 'It's not us, it's you!'

Conclusion

The post-2020 overhaul of the curriculum for *Liberal Studies* / CSD signals a decisive shift from an emphasis on fostering qualities (such as consciousness of ethical, cultural and political diversity) essential to the responsible exercise of participatory citizenship, towards imposition of a homogenous and totalising vision of Hong Kong-as-Chinese. Encouraging pupils confronted with social or political complexity to exercise autonomous judgement is off the agenda; instead, the curriculum now mandates didactic inculcation of Beijing's version of political correctness, underpinned by a unilinear narrative of Hong Kong's 'rootedness' in Chinese history and culture. The shift from *Liberal Studies* to CSD thus illustrates the growing 'culturalisation of politics' that Chen observes in relation to the introduction in mainland China of compulsory lessons in Xi Jinping Thought (Chen 2023). While within Hong Kong, political and ideological discourse pays less direct or explicit homage to the CCP and the person of Xi himself than on the mainland, a growing convergence in narratives of history, culture, values and identity is clear.

Official discourse meanwhile reduces youth alienation to a matter of individual psychological deviance. With critique of the established order now outlawed as treasonous, explanations for public discontent must be sought at the level of private or individual maladaptation. This is a pattern long evident in CCP campaigns for 'gratitude education' directed at various restive populations in China (Wan and Vickers *forthcoming*). Lui and Cheung are among local scholars struggling to tread an increasingly perilous line – between integrity and the imperative to lend critical analysis a 'sincere' or 'loyal' flavour. But even their tactful critique comes at the price of marginalisation within the new order, their places taken by local proxies of China's Party-State.

Meanwhile, the struggle to which some scholars remain committed is one for which many expatriate academics and foreign observers have failed to turn up (Baehr 2022). In an Anglophone academic milieu where sweeping attacks on 'hegemonic Western modernity' elicit automatic applause, forceful critique of China sits uneasily with many self-styled progressives (Vickers 2020). While some cheer Hong Kong's integration into the 'Greater Bay Area' (Xie (谢爱磊), Postiglione, and Huang (黄倩) 2021), and others parrot the CCP's culturally essentialist contrast of 'Chinese' with 'Western' values (Marginson and Yang 2022), most choose silence. Western-trained scholars often struggle to find the language, concepts or courage to challenge a *kulturkampf* waged by a non-Western state against a society marked by legacies of Western colonialism. As Carrico

observes, the tendency to attribute anti-Chinese sentiment in Hong Kong, Taiwan or Tibet to 'Western influence' replaces 'real political struggles with a new imaginary Orient, cleansed of internal conflict for the sake of a false analytical coherence and a feel-good narrative' (Carrico 2018).⁸

Hong Kong thus stands as a warning of how 'decolonial' thinking, in obsessing over the 'pedigree' of ideas, can overlook the importance of native 'agency' (Táiwò 2022). That the rule of law, or civil rights, or Hong Kong's separate status itself, trace their origins to British colonialism, becomes sufficient to cast doubt on their legitimacy, irrespective of local residents' wishes. Western decolonialists and Chinese neo-fascists converge on a nihilistic cultural relativism that can be invoked to justify craven submission to power. Jiang Shigong, the legal scholar influential in shaping CCP thinking on Hong Kong's constitutional status, draws on both Carl Schmitt, Hitler's 'Crown Jurist' who asserted absolute state supremacy over the individual (Chang 2020), and Foucault, who followed Nietzsche in conflating 'knowledge' with 'power' (Jiang 2007).

The 2020 National Security Law codifies a Schmittian interpretation of Hong Kong's constitutional order, which is reflected in new curricula and textbooks. Through CSD, alongside other school subjects, public history and the media, official discourse openly politicises the national and local past – portraying Chinese pedigree as destiny – while thoroughly depoliticising the present and future. In fulfilment of a fascist vision of culture, race and state sovereignty, politics in the new Hong Kong is no longer presented as an arena for civic agency, but as a stage for performing patriotic loyalty. Analysing this process while respecting the agency of Hongkongers themselves will require many scholars to re-examine both their conceptual apparatus and their consciences.

Notes

1. <https://cbleportal.edb.edcity.hk/> (accessed September 10, 2022).
2. <https://nslexhibition.hk/> (accessed November 23, 2022).
3. For a full list of members, see https://hk.history.museum/en_US/web/mh/exhibition/permanent/hksrenovation/expert-advisory-panel.html (accessed November 1, 2022).
4. For Liang's full text see: https://so.gushiwen.cn/shiwen/_9ebe5eef393d.aspx (accessed March 3, 2023).
5. The HKEPC 'Hong Kong Today' volume was co-authored by Hui Tai Mei Har, an experienced educator and teacher trainer. For the CSD equivalent, Hui was replaced by Wong Chi Fai. Two other authors were retained.
6. On the taboo surrounding 'refugees', see Vickers (2005, 166).
7. Conducted online, January 7, 2023. <https://www.eduhk.hk/aps/policy-dialogue-series-7-jan-2023-giving-hope-to-young-people-what-matters-and-how/>.
8. On October 10, 2022, Carrico and I joined a webinar on *Sinophobia* hosted by National Yang Ming Chiao Tung University (Taiwan), where the French scholar, Alain Brossat, denounced Hongkongese and Taiwanese pro-democracy protesters as 'cultural renegades'.

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